

LSBUD Foresight

Householder Safe Digging Checklist

A practical pre-work checklist for small domestic projects such as extensions, driveways, fencing, landscaping, drainage and repair works. Use this checklist before any ground is broken.

Golden rule: Assume every buried service is live until proved otherwise. Plans and markings reduce risk, but safe digging practice is still required.

Before you start - plans and permissions

Check	Action	Done
Asset plans	Submit a OneCall / LSBUD enquiry for the planned work area. Check whether the response identifies affected asset owners and any special conditions.	■
Non-LSBUD asset owners	Contact companies not covered by the LSBUD response. If you want a broader search route, consider an LSBUD Top-Up service.	■
Tree preservation orders	Check whether trees or hedges are protected before excavation, trenching, service installation or root-zone works.	■
Environmental restrictions	Check for watercourses, protected habitats, protected species, contamination, invasive species and other environmental restrictions.	■
Site constraints	Review access, slopes, unstable ground, retaining walls, cellars, culverts, drainage, overhead lines, nearby structures and public interfaces.	■

Walk the site - look, trace and mark

Check	Action	Done
Visible clues	Locate stopcocks, meter boxes, inspection covers, gullies, valve covers, cable ducts, service entries, outbuildings and old service scars.	■
Trace logical service routes	Trace lines logically from stopcocks, meters and covers to home intake points. Do not assume routes run straight or at standard depth.	■
Mark before digging	Mark likely routes using spray paint, flags, stakes or temporary marking. Keep markings visible throughout the works.	■
Check against plans	Compare physical site evidence against utility plans. Treat contradictions, missing information and unclear routes as higher risk.	■

Safe digging controls

Check	Action	Done
Assume live	Treat every service as live. Do not rely on age, appearance, depth or lack of recent use.	■
Trial holes	Use hand-dug trial holes to expose services carefully where the route is uncertain or where work crosses a suspected service.	■

Check	Action	Done
Hand tools near services	Use insulated hand tools and controlled excavation near expected services. Avoid aggressive picks, forks and mechanical tools close to marked routes.	■
Mechanical excavation	Keep mechanical excavation away from suspected or exposed services unless a competent safe system of work is in place.	■
Support exposed services	Do not leave exposed pipes, cables or ducts unsupported. Protect from impact, bending, crushing, heat and sharp edges.	■

Emergency readiness

Check	Action	Done
Contacts ready	Have emergency contacts ready before work starts: gas emergency, electricity network operator, water company, telecoms provider, site owner and emergency services.	■
Stop work	If a strike, damage, smell of gas, arcing, flooding, unexpected service or unsafe condition occurs, stop work immediately and keep people clear.	■
Do not repair	Do not attempt to repair damaged services yourself. Isolate only if safe and instructed by the relevant network or emergency service.	■
Record and report	Record location, photographs, time, people involved and actions taken. Report near misses and update the site markings and plan notes.	■

Quick reference - emergency prompts

Situation	Immediate action
Gas smell or damaged gas pipe	Stop work, extinguish ignition sources if safe, evacuate the area, call the gas emergency number and prevent re-entry.
Electricity cable damage or arcing	Keep clear, warn others, do not touch machinery or cable, call the electricity network emergency contact and emergency services if required.
Water main or sewer damage	Stop work, move people away from flooding or contamination, contact the water company and protect excavations from collapse.
Unknown service found	Stop work, mark the location, keep service exposed and protected, update the risk assessment and seek competent advice.

Reminder: This checklist supports safe planning; it does not replace competent advice, statutory duties, asset owner instructions or site-specific risk assessment.